

**HABBINSON**

PERSONALITY & ENTREPRENEURSHIP SCHOOL



— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

# 3 ways to practice this week

Stop handing kids the answer. Learn how asking 'what's your plan?' builds problem-solving, initiative, and leadership — and raises a child who thinks for themselves.

**5**

ACTION STEPS

**6**

EXPERT FAQs

**3**

RESEARCH SOURCES

#### THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

*Your child hits a problem and looks up at you with those eyes: fix it for me. And because you love them (and you're busy), you do. Quick answer, problem solved, everyone moves on. But you just did the most valuable part — the thinking — for them.*

#### — THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

## 3 ways to practice this week

#### QUICK ANSWER

How can parents build problem-solving skills in kids? Resist solving problems for them. When your child is stuck, ask questions instead of giving answers: "What's your plan? What have you tried? What could you do next?" This keeps the thinking with the child, so they practice planning, weighing options, and acting — the core of problem-solving.

#### — WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

**The APA's work on children and independence shows kids who get to make decisions build stronger judgment and confidence in their own ideas.**

Sources: [Harvard](#) | [APA](#) | [CDC](#)

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**— DO THIS**

## The questions that grow a thinker

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

**1**

**"What's your plan?" — the opener that**  
hands it back.

**2**

**"What have you already tried?" — makes**  
them review, not restart.

**3**

**"What are two things you could do?"**  
— builds the habit of options.

**4**

**"What do you think will happen if**  
you do that?" — grows foresight.

**5**

**"How did that work out**  
What would you change?" — turns the result into learning.

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**— COMMON QUESTIONS**

## Quick answers for parents

### **What if my child's plan is wrong?**

Let them try it if it's safe. A plan that flops is a powerful teacher — ask "how did that go, and what would you change?" Kids learn more from a small, safe failure they own than from a correct answer you hand them.

### **My child just says 'I don't know.' What then?**

That's often a reflex, not the truth. Wait quietly, then offer a nudge: "What are two things you could try?" Resist filling the silence. Most kids will think if they realize you're not going to rescue them.

### **Isn't it faster to just tell them?**

Today, yes. Long term, no. Every answer you hand over is a thinking rep your child misses. A few extra minutes now builds a child who can solve their own problems later — saving you far more time down the road.

### **At what age should I start asking instead of telling?**

As soon as they can talk in sentences. Keep it simple for little ones — "What could we try?" — and let the questions grow more complex as they do. It's never too early or too late.

### **Won't this frustrate my child?**

A little friction is fine — that's the brain working. Keep your tone warm and supportive, not testing. If they're truly overwhelmed, step in with a hint. The goal is a stretch, not a struggle that shuts them down.

### **How does this help with confidence?**

Every problem a child solves themselves proves they're capable. That proof, stacked up over time, becomes genuine confidence — the quiet, durable kind that comes from "I did it," not from being told they're great.

READING HELPS. PRACTICE STICKS.

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